

ACT II: THE VOID (HYPER-EXPANDED)

CHAPTER 7: THE TRASH COMPACTOR

LOCATION: THE VOID

TIMELINE: NULL

The fall didn't feel like falling. Falling implies direction. Falling implies that there is a "down" to go to.

This felt like being un-written.

One moment, I was standing on the plush, ugly carpet of Mr. Paradox's office, smelling the faint scent of his expensive cologne (Sandalwood and sociopathy). The next, the floor was gone. The air was gone. Reality was gone.

I was tumbling through a kaleidoscope of orange static.

It wasn't cold. It wasn't hot. It was the temperature of nothing. It was the feeling of your foot falling asleep, but applied to your entire existence.

Flash.

I saw things in the static. Glimpses of other places. Other times.

I saw a world where I was Batman. (The suit nipples were aggressive).

I saw a world where I was a barista.

I saw a world where I was happy.

Don't look, the voice in my head whispered. *It's a trap. It's the 'It's a Wonderful Life' montage before the suicide attempt.*

Then, the orange faded. Gravity returned with a vengeance.

WHOOSH.

Air. Real air. Dirty, hot, stagnant air.

I was falling through a sky the color of a three-day-old bruise. Purple. Grey. Angry.

Below me, the ground was rushing up. A landscape of rust and ruin.

"Oh, fu—"

CRASH.

I hit a dune.

Sand forced its way into my nose, my mouth, my ears. It wasn't soft beach sand. It was coarse. Sharp. It tasted of metal and ash.

I rolled. Tumbling down the side of the dune. My shoulder hit a piece of rebar sticking out of the ground like a rusted rib.

Snk.

It went through my trap.

"Gah!"

I stopped rolling. I lay there, face down in the dirt.

Pain.

Glorious, familiar, grounding pain. It anchored me. It told me I wasn't dead. Dead people don't feel rebar in their trapezius.

I groaned. I pushed myself up. The rebar slid out with a wet *shhhhk*. Blood—hot and sticky—trickled down my back.

"Okay," I wheezed. "Okay. That happened."

I spat out a mouthful of grit. I wiped my mask.

I looked up.

The scale of the place hit me like a physical blow.

It was endless. A desert of junk. Mountains of scrap metal. Skyscrapers that had been twisted like taffy. And the sky...

The sky was alive.

A cloud. A massive, purple, roiling storm. It had eyes. It had a mouth. It roared, a sound that wasn't sound, but a vibration in the bone.

Alioth.

The Guardian. The Dog. The Vacuum Cleaner.

This is it, I thought. *This is the landfill. This is where the TVA flushes the toilet.*

I scanned the horizon.

"Logan!" I shouted.

My voice sounded small. Pathetic. It was swallowed instantly by the wind.

"Wolvie! Peanut! Hairball!"

Nothing.

Just the wind howling through the hollowed-out skull of a Giant-Man.

I started walking.

My boots crunched on the debris. I stepped over a license plate that said "GOTHAM". I stepped over a shield made of vibranium (dented). I stepped over a copy of the *E.T.* Atari game.

"The horror," I whispered.

Then I saw it.

A boot. A yellow boot.

Sticking out of a pile of tires.

I ran. My lungs burned. The air here was thin, metallic. It tasted like sucking on a penny.

I clawed at the tires. "Logan!"

I pulled him out.

He was heavy. Dense. Like moving a statue made of meat.

He was unconscious. His face was a mask of blood and mud. His healing factor was working—I could see the skin knitting together over a gash on his forehead—but it was slow. The Void dampened everything. Even miracles.

"Wake up," I slapped his cheek. *Thwack.*

He didn't move.

"Wake up!" I slapped him harder.

His eyes snapped open.

Yellow. Bloodshot. Feral.

He didn't say "Thank you." He didn't say "Where are we?"

He popped his claws. *SNIKT.*

He tried to stab me.

It was a lazy stab. Drunk. Slow. I leaned back, and the claws swiped the air an inch from my nose.

"Easy, tiger," I said. "You're hungover. You're pruned. You're in a bad mood. I get it."

He tried to stand. He stumbled. He fell to his knees.

He vomited.

It was mostly whiskey. Clear. Pungent. It splashed onto the sand, sizzling slightly.

"Classy," I said.

Logan wiped his mouth. He looked up at me.

"You," he growled.

"Me," I agreed.

"You shot me."

"I did. In the head. It was the only way to get you through security. Think of it as a sedative. A very

loud, lead-based sedative."

He looked around. He saw the purple sky. He saw Alioth.

"Where is this?"

"The Void," I said. "The end of time. The place where bad ideas go to die."

I gestured to the landscape.

"And guess what? We're the newest exhibit."

Logan stared at the horizon. He looked... small.

For the first time, I realized that the suit—the yellow and blue suit—wasn't just a costume. It was a target. It was bright. It was loud. In this world of grey and rust, he was a neon sign saying "EAT ME."

"We need cover," I said. "Before the cloud dog sees us."

He didn't argue. He just stood up, swaying.

"I need a drink," he said.

"Of course you do," I sighed. "Come on. I smell ozone and... is that chimichangas? No. Probably rotting flesh. But let's follow it anyway."

CHAPTER 8: A MAN-SHAPED SCAR

We walked for an hour. Or a day. Time didn't work here. The sun (if it was a sun) didn't move. It just hung in the sky, a pale, sickly eye.

We found shelter in the fuselage of a crashed Helicarrier.

It was massive. A metal whale beached on the sand. The S.H.I.E.L.D. logo was faded, scratched out by claws bigger than anything I wanted to think about.

Inside, someone had built a bar.

Because of course they had. Even at the end of the world, people need to forget.

It was makeshift. Tables made of cable spools. Stools made of buckets. The bar itself was a piece of wing flap.

The bartender was a variant. A guy with green skin and three eyes. He didn't ask for ID. He just pointed to a bottle.

Logan sat down. He slumped.

The table was sticky. Decades of spilled drinks and unwashed hands. It smelled of yeast and despair.

"Two," Logan rasped. "Leave the bottle."

The bartender slid a bottle of clear liquid toward us. It had no label. Just a skull drawn in marker.

Logan uncorked it with his teeth. He spat the cork onto the floor.

He drank.

He didn't sip. He swallowed half the bottle in one go. His throat worked. His eyes watered.

"Jesus," I said. "Pace yourself, peanut. That stuff looks like it could strip paint."

Logan slammed the bottle down. *Bang.*

"Shut up," he said.

"We need a plan," I said. "We need to find a way back. Paradox said—"

"I don't care what he said," Logan interrupted. "I'm not going back."

"What?"

"I'm done." He looked at his hands.

His hands were scarred. Not the healing factor scars. These were deeper. Lines of guilt etched into the skin. His knuckles were raw.

"I failed," he whispered.

The bar went quiet. Even the three-eyed bartender stopped polishing a glass.

"My world," Logan said. "It's gone. Because of me."

I watched him.

This wasn't the Wolverine from the lunchboxes. This wasn't the hero who posed for statues.

This was a man who had lived too long. A man who was tired of surviving.

"Tell me," I said.

He looked at me. His eyes were haunted.

"The humans came," he said. "They had new Sentinels. Quiet ones. They slipped into the mansion at night."

He gripped the bottle. The glass creaked.

"I was at a bar," he said. "Just like this one. Three miles away. I heard the alarms. I heard the screams. But I... I didn't move."

"Why?" I asked.

"Because I hated them," he confessed. "That day. I hated them. Scott. Jean. Xavier. They were so perfect. So judgmental. I wanted them to suffer. Just for a minute."

A tear leaked out of his eye. It cut a clean track through the dirt on his face.

"But a minute was all it took."

He looked down.

"When I got there... the fire was already out. They were all dead. Every single one."

He drank again.

"I killed the soldiers," he said. "I killed them all. It took me three days. I hunted them down. I popped my claws and I turned them into meat."

He looked at his claws. They were halfway out, gleaming in the dim light.

"But it didn't bring them back."

I sat there.

I felt cold.

This wasn't a tragic backstory. This was a confession. This was a sin so heavy it had crushed a timeline.

He's the Anchor, I thought. *But he's not holding the ship. He's dragging it down.*

I reached out. I touched his hand.

His skin was rough. Calloused. Warm.

"Logan," I said.

He pulled his hand away. "Don't."

"We can fix it," I said. "Maybe not your world. But mine. You can save mine."

"I don't save things, Wade," he said. "I break them."

He stood up.

"I'm leaving."

"Where?"

"To find a hole. And stay in it."

He turned to the door.

"No," I said.

I stood up. I blocked his path.

"Get out of my way."

"No. You owe me. You owe the universe. You don't get to quit. Not yet."

He growled. A low, animal rumble.

"Move."

"Make me."

He popped his claws fully. *SNIKT.*

The sound echoed in the hollow fuselage.

"Fine," he said.

CHAPTER 9: THE HOSTAGE DEAL

****LOCATION: OUTSIDE THE BAR (THE HONDA ODYSSEY)****

The fight spilled out into the sand.

We crashed into the side of a minivan. A Honda Odyssey. Gold. 2011. The pinnacle of suburban engineering.

"Shotgun!" I yelled, throwing him through the passenger window.

I jumped in the driver's side.

"Start the car!" I shouted. "We're taking this discussion on the road!"

"I'm going to gut you!" Logan roared.

He lunged across the center console.

The space was too small. It was intimate. It was violent.

Beat 1: Mechanics.

Logan's left claw punched through the dashboard plastic. *CRUNCH.* Sparks flew from the radio.

His right claw went for my neck.

I caught his wrist. My grip strength against his Adamantium skeleton. It was like trying to hold back a hydraulic press.

I jammed my thumb into the wound on his shoulder—the bullet hole.

"Ow!" he yelled.

Beat 2: Consequence.

He headbutted me.

My nose exploded. Cartilage and bone turned to mush.

Blood blinded me.

I kicked him. My boot connected with his midsection. He slammed back against the door. The window shattered. *CRASH.*

"You broke the window!" I screamed. "There goes the resale value!"

Beat 3: Aftertaste.

We were panting. Bleeding.

The car smelled of blood and old French fries.

My nose knitted itself back together with a series of wet *clicks*.

Logan pulled his claw out of the dashboard. It came free with a screech of tearing plastic.

"Are you done?" I asked.

"No," he said.

"Good. Me neither."

I turned the key.

The engine sputtered. Then... it caught.

Vroom.

The radio came to life.

Avril Lavigne. 'I'm with You'.

I looked at Logan.

He looked at me. He had a piece of dashboard stuck in his hair.

"It's a sign," I said.

"It's hell," he corrected.

I slammed the car into drive. We peeled out, spraying sand.

"Where are we going?" Logan demanded.

"To find the bad guy," I said. "Every story needs a villain. And I heard she lives in a skull."

Logan sank back into the seat. He retracted his claws. *Snikt.*

He looked out the window at the endless grey wasteland.

"I hate you," he said.

"I know," I said. "But you're stuck with me. Just you, me, and Avril."

I cranked the volume.

"IT'S A DAMN COLD NIGHT!" I sang.

Logan closed his eyes.

He didn't kill me.

That was progress.

CHAPTER 10: THE MIND TOUCH

****LOCATION: THE BORDERLANDS****

****POV: CASSANDRA NOVA****

The mind is not a book. People say "read my mind," but they are wrong.

A mind is a meal.

Cassandra Nova sat on her throne. It was built from the ossified remains of a Celestial's thumb. Smooth, white bone, cool to the touch.

She ran a finger along the armrest.

"Bring them," she whispered.

Her voice didn't need to be loud. It carried on the psychic wind.

She closed her eyes and extended her senses.

The Void was a buffet.

There were the small snacks: the scavengers, the lost variants. Their minds were simple. Hunger. Fear. Greed. They tasted like stale popcorn.

Then there was Alioth. The cloud beast. His mind was a storm. A hurricane of hunger. He tasted of ozone and static. Too spicy.

But the new arrivals...

She licked her lips.

One was... chaotic.

Wade Wilson.

His mind was a funhouse mirror maze. Thoughts bounced and refracted. He knew he was in a story. He knew **she** was in a story. It was disorienting. It tasted like Pop Rocks and battery acid. A sour, fizzy explosion on the tongue.

Deliciously annoying, she thought.

But the other one.

Logan.

She inhaled deeply through her nose.

His mind was a cellar. Deep. Dark. Damp.

She pushed past the surface thoughts—the anger, the pain, the desire for whiskey. She went deeper.

She tasted the Adamantium. It was a cold, metallic tang. It tasted of violation. Of being cut open and filled with something that didn't belong.

She went deeper.

She tasted the memories.

1845. A sickbed. A scream. Bone claws popping for the first time. The taste of a father's blood.

The wars. Civil. World 1. World 2. Vietnam. Mud. Blood. Jungle rot.

The Weapon X program. The tank. The wires. The feeling of drowning in green fluid.

And then... the fresh wound.

Westchester.

It tasted of ash. Of burning wood. Of betrayal.

Cassandra shuddered. A wave of pleasure rolled through her.

"Oh," she whispered. "He is exquisitely broken."

She opened her eyes.

Her lieutenants—Pyro, Sabretooth, Toad—were watching her. They looked nervous. They knew that when she was hungry, anyone could be on the menu.

"The Wolverine," Cassandra said. "I want him alive. I want to peel him apart, layer by layer. I want to see what's at the center of all that pain."

She looked at Pyro.

"Burn the red one," she said. "He tastes like cheap plastic. But bring me the animal."

CHAPTER 11: THE GAUNTLET - PART 1 (THE SETTLEMENT)

LOCATION: THE RIB CAGE

We parked the Odyssey behind a dune.

"Stealth mode," I whispered.

Logan looked at the bright gold minivan. "We're in a gold van, Wade. There is no stealth mode."

"It's camouflage," I argued. "We blend in with the... majestic gold sands of the Void."

"The sand is grey."

"Details."

We walked toward the settlement.

It was built inside the ribcage of a Giant-Man. The bones arched over the camp like the vaulted ceiling of a cathedral made of calcium.

The smell hit us first.

It was the smell of unwashed humanity concentrated in a small space. Sweat. Urine. Cooking meat (of dubious origin).

We moved through the crowd.

Variants. Hundreds of them.

I saw a Gambit. He was dealing cards to a Blob.

I saw a Daredevil (the Ben Affleck one). He looked sad.

I saw a Howard the Duck. He was roasting a rat on a stick.

"Keep your head down," Logan muttered.

He pulled his collar up. He was trying to hide, but you can't hide presence. He walked like a predator. People moved out of his way instinctively.

We found the fuel depot. A tanker truck guarded by a Toad variant.

"We need gas," Logan said.

Toad looked up. He spat a sunflower seed shell. "Trade?"

"I have a kidney," I offered. "It grows back. It's a renewable resource."

Toad ignored me. He looked at Logan.

"The jacket," Toad said. "Leather. Real leather."

Logan touched his jacket. It was old. Battered. It was the only thing he owned.

"No," Logan said.

"Then no gas."

I stepped forward. "Look, Kermit. We're on a mission from God. Or at least, a god-complex bureaucrat. We need the go-juice."

Toad smiled. It was wide and wet.

"There is another way," Toad said.

He pointed to a cage.

Inside, a boy. Glowing blue eyes. He was shivering.

"The Boss wants the kid," Toad said. "Cassandra. She collects... power sources. You take the kid to the Borderlands, I give you a full tank."

I looked at the kid. He looked like he was twelve. He looked like he knew exactly what was happening.

I looked at Logan.

His jaw tightened. A muscle jumped in his cheek.

He's remembering, I thought. *He's remembering the kids he didn't save.*

"We're not slavers," Logan growled.

"Then walk," Toad said.

We walked away.

"We take the fuel," Logan whispered when we were out of earshot.

"And the kid?"

Logan stopped. He looked at the massive white ribs curving above us.

"We can't save everyone, Wade."

"We can save *him*."

"If we start a fight, the whole camp comes down on us. We die. Your world dies."

"So we just leave him? To Cassandra? You know what she does to minds. You felt it."

Logan looked at his hands.

"I know."

"Then let's do something stupid," I said. "Let's be the X-Men."

He looked at me.

"I'm not an X-Man."

"You're wearing the suit," I pointed out. "Yellow and blue. The colors of 'I make bad decisions for the right reasons'."

He sighed. A long, weary exhale.

"I take the guards," he said. "You get the kid."

"Deal."

That night, we didn't just steal gas. We started a riot.

The Raid.

Logan moved like smoke. He took out the perimeter guards silently. *Snap. Crunch. Thud.* No claws. Just efficiency.

I crept to the cage.

"Hey, kid," I whispered. "You like road trips?"

The boy looked up. "Who are you?"

"I'm the fairy godmother," I said, picking the lock. "But with more cancer and guns."

The lock clicked.

CLANG.

I dropped the lock.

"Oops."

The camp woke up.

Toad screamed. "Get them!"

And then... chaos.

Mutants everywhere. Pyro blasting fire. A Quill guy shooting spikes.

Logan dropped the stealth. *SNIKT.*

He became a whirlwind. He cut through the mob. He wasn't killing them—mostly—he was just disabling them. A slash to the leg. A punch to the gut.

I grabbed the kid. "Run to the van! The gold one!"

We sprinted.

Fireballs exploded around us. The heat was intense. It singed my suit.

We made it to the van. Logan jumped in the driver's seat.

"Hold on!"

He gunned it. The Odyssey roared (or purred aggressively).

We smashed through the gate. We hit the open sand.

I looked back. The camp was a hornet's nest.

"We did it!" I yelled. "We saved the—"

THUNK.

An arrow hit the back window. It exploded.

"Why is it always the windows?" I complained. "Do you know how hard it is to get safety glass in the Void?"

The kid was huddled in the back seat. He was glowing.

"Thank you," he whispered.

Logan looked in the rearview mirror. He met the kid's eyes.

For a second, the hardness in Logan's face melted.

"Don't thank us yet," Logan said. "We're not safe."

CHAPTER 12: THE GAUNTLET - PART 2 (THE RUINS)

LOCATION: THE 20th CENTURY FOX LOT

We dropped the kid off at a resistance outpost a few miles down the road. (Yes, there's a resistance. It's mostly just people who haven't been eaten yet).

We kept driving.

The landscape shifted. The organic rot gave way to concrete skeletons.

We stopped at a massive ruin half-buried in the sand.

I got out. I wiped the dust off a stone block.

20th CENTURY FOX.

The monolith. The fanfare structure. The symbol of my corporate origin.

I sat on the giant 'X'.

It was cold. The stone was rough, pitted by the Void winds.

"This is it," I said. "This is where I came from."

Logan stood next to me. He looked at the ruin.

"It's just rocks," he said.

"It's not just rocks," I said. "It's history. It's *X-Men*. It's *Daredevil*. It's *Elektra*! Okay, maybe we don't talk about *Elektra*. But it was home."

I looked at the 'F'. It was cracked.

"They bought it," I said. "Disney. They bought the whole thing. And then... they pruned it. They sent it all here."

I felt a genuine pang of grief. Not for a studio. But for the era. For the messy, weird, inconsistent movies that made me.

"Everything ends," Logan said.

He sat down next to me. He pulled out a cigar stub. He didn't light it. He just chewed on it.

"Does it have to?" I asked. "Why does it have to end? Why can't we just... keep going?"

"Because nothing lasts," Logan said. "Not studios. Not heroes. Not us."

He looked at the horizon. The purple sky was swirling.

"I miss them," I whispered. "Vanessa. Blind Al. Even Weasel. I miss my world. I don't want it to be

just... rocks in a desert."

"Then fight for it," Logan said.

"I am," I said. "But I'm tired, Wovie. I'm so tired. Being the funny guy... it's exhausting. It's heavy."

He looked at me.

He put a hand on my shoulder. It was heavy. Warm. It was the first time he had touched me without trying to kill me.

"Me too, kid," he said. "Me too."

We sat there for a long time. Two relics of a dead universe, sitting on the tombstone of the company that created us.

The wind howled. It sounded like the opening fanfare, played on a broken trumpet.

CHAPTER 13: THE GAUNTLET - PART 3 (THE AMBUSH)

****LOCATION: THE CANYON****

The ambush happened in the canyon.

It was a text-book kill zone. High walls. Narrow choke point.

BOOM.

An explosion rocked the buggy (we had traded the Odyssey for a buggy at the resistance camp. Better suspension. Less legroom).

We flipped.

The world spun. Sky. Ground. Sky. Ground. Pain.

I crawled out of the wreckage. My leg was bent at a 90-degree angle. I snapped it back.

CRUNCH.

"Motherfluffer!" I screamed.

"Wade!" Logan yelled.

I looked up.

Logan was pinned. The chassis of the buggy was on his chest. He was pushing, veins popping, but it was heavy.

And standing over him...

Sabretooth.

Not the Liev Schreiber one. The Tyler Mane one. The big one. The one who looked like a lion that ate a wrestler.

"Well, well," Sabretooth growled. His voice was deep, a rumble in the earth. "The runt."

"Victor," Logan wheezed.

"I've been waiting for this," Sabretooth said. "A long time."

He extended his claws. They were dirty. Yellow.

I tried to run. I tried to help.

But Pyro was there.

He stood on a ridge. He snapped his fingers.

FWOOSH.

A wall of fire cut me off.

"Stay back, freak," Pyro yelled.

I rolled. The heat singed my eyebrows.

I watched, helpless, as Sabretooth raised his hand.

"Time to die, Jimmy," Sabretooth grinned.

Beat 1: Mechanics.

Logan didn't try to lift the car. He stopped pushing. He let the weight settle.

Then, he exploded.

He popped his claws *through* the metal door of the buggy, stabbing upward into Sabretooth's foot.

Sabretooth howled. He stepped back, hopping.

Logan used the moment. He bench-pressed the chassis. *HNNNG.* He threw it off.

He stood up. He was bleeding from his chest. His suit was torn.

Beat 2: Consequence.

They collided.

It wasn't a martial arts fight. It was two animals trying to eat each other.

Claws met claws. *SPARK.*

Sabretooth bit Logan's shoulder. He tore a chunk of flesh out.

Logan didn't scream. He stabbed Sabretooth in the gut. Three claws deep.

They rolled in the dirt. Fur. Blood. Dust.

Beat 3: Aftertaste.

Logan got the upper hand.

He pinned Sabretooth.

He put his claws to Sabretooth's neck.

"Do it!" Sabretooth hissed. "Do it, runt!"

Logan didn't hesitate.

SNICK-SLICE.

He took the head off.

The head rolled. It stopped at my feet. Sabretooth's eyes were still open, frozen in a look of surprise.

Logan stood up. He was panting. Blood—his and Victor's—covered him.

He looked wild. He looked like the animal everyone said he was.

He looked at me.

"Logan?" I whispered.

He blinked. The animal receded. The man came back.

He fell to his knees.

"Let's go," he said. "Before I eat him."

CHAPTER 14: THE AFTERMATH

****LOCATION: THE CANYON CAMP****

We didn't go far. We found a cave. It smelled of bat guano and damp stone, but it was defensible.

We built a fire.

Logan sat by the entrance, staring out at the dark. He was cleaning his claws again. The rag was turning black with Sabretooth's blood.

I watched him.

His healing factor was working. The bite on his shoulder was already a pink scar. But the look in his eyes... that wasn't healing. That was festering.

"You okay?" I asked.

"I killed my brother," he said.

"He was trying to kill you," I pointed out. "And me. And probably a lot of other people."

"He's still my brother."

He scrubbed a spot on his claw that wouldn't come clean.

"In my timeline," Logan said, "Victor and I... we fought for a century. Back to back. We were monsters together."

He looked at the fire.

"I thought... I thought maybe here, in the Void... maybe he'd be different. Maybe we could have..."

He trailed off.

"Redemption?" I offered.

"Peace," he corrected. "Just peace."

I moved closer to the fire. The warmth felt good on my skin.

"There is no peace for guys like us, Wolvie. We're weapons. We're built for war."

"I'm tired of war," he whispered.

"Me too," I said. "But the war isn't over. Not yet."

I pulled a chimichanga out of my pouch. It was squashed. Cold.

"Want half?" I offered.

He looked at the sad, flat burrito.

"No."

"More for me."

We ate in silence. The fire crackled. Outside, Alioth roared in the distance.

It was a grim night. But we were alive.

CHAPTER 15: THE SILENCE

****LOCATION: THE OPEN PLAIN****

The next day was a slog.

The buggy had a flat tire. We fixed it with duct tape and hope.

We drove across an endless grey plain. The silence in the car was heavy. It wasn't the angry silence of before. It was a thoughtful silence. A mourning silence.

"You know," I said, "that decapitation last night? Solid 9 out of 10. You lost a point for the landing."

Logan didn't growl. He just adjusted his grip on the wheel.

"Don't push it," he said.

"I'm just saying. You have style. You have flair. You could be a dancer. *Magic Mike XXL: Mutant Mayhem*."

"Stop."

"Okay. Stopping."

I looked out the window.

"We make a good team," I said softly.

Logan didn't answer immediately. He looked at the road.

"We're not a team," he said. "We're two idiots in a buggy."

"Two idiots who killed Sabretooth," I corrected. "Two idiots who are going to save the world."

He glanced at me.

"Maybe," he said.

It wasn't a yes. But it wasn't a no.

CHAPTER 16: THE CAMPFIRE (SETUP)

We camped near a cluster of rocks that looked like teeth jutting out of the ground.

The wind had picked up. It howled through the gaps in the stone, sounding like a chorus of ghosts.

We huddled near the fire.

"Why do you wear the suit?" Logan asked suddenly.

I looked up. He was staring at my red spandex.

"Because it hides the blood," I said. "Classic line. True story."

"No," he said. "Why do *you* wear it? You could wear anything. You could be anyone."

"It's who I am," I said. "It's the only thing that fits. Wade Wilson is... messy. Deadpool is clean. Deadpool has a script."

I looked at his suit. The yellow and blue.

"Why do *you* wear it?" I asked. "You never wore it in the movies. You hated it."

Logan looked down. He touched the yellow fabric.

"Scott," he said. "Scott wanted me to wear it."

"Cyclops?"

"Yeah. He said... he said the X-Men needed to be symbols. Bright. Hopeful. He said people needed to see us coming and know that help had arrived."

He laughed. A bitter, dry sound.

"I told him he was an idiot. I told him I wasn't a billboard. I told him I wasn't a hero. I told him to take his yellow spandex and shove it."

He traced the X on his belt.

"I never wore it. Not once. Until..."

He stopped.

"Until the funeral?" I asked.

He nodded.

"I put it on," he whispered. "After they died. I put it on to bury them. Because... because I wanted them to know I was one of them. Finally. I wanted them to know I was on the team."

He looked at me. The firelight danced in his wet eyes.

"But it was too late. They were dead. And I was just a clown in a yellow suit standing over a grave."

CHAPTER 17: THE CONFESSION

****THE BESTSELLER MOMENT****

The fire popped. A spark flew up into the dark sky, joining the fake stars.

I looked at him. The Wolverine. The legend. The man on the lunchbox.

He looked small. He looked broken.

He bleeds like it matters. I bleed like a punchline.

"I didn't just ignore the call," Logan said. His voice was barely a whisper. "I was... I was afraid."

I froze.

"Afraid?"

"I was afraid that if I went... I'd kill them."

He looked at his hands. His knuckles were white.

"I lose control, Wade. You know that. The Berserker Rage. It's not a superpower. It's a disease. It's a fire in my brain. I was afraid I'd hurt Jeannie. Or the kids. Or Scott."

Tears leaked out of his eyes. He didn't wipe them away. They tracked through the dirt on his cheeks.

"So I stayed away. I drank. I told myself I was protecting them by not being there. I told myself I was the danger."

He sobbed. A racking, ugly sound.

"But they needed me. The humans... they came with Sentinels. They slaughtered them. And I was safe in a bar, staring at a bottle of whiskey."

He looked at me. His face was a mask of agony.

"I didn't kill them, Wade. But I let them die. Is there a difference?"

I stared at him.

I wanted to make a joke. I wanted to say something about how that's a classic trope. I wanted to diffuse the tension because the tension was crushing me.

But I couldn't.

Because he was right.

And because I knew exactly how he felt.

I stood up. I walked around the fire.

I sat down next to him.

I didn't hug him. He would have stabbed me.

I just sat there. Shoulder to shoulder. Two broken men in the dark.

"No," I said. "There isn't a difference. But you're here now."

"Does it matter?" he asked.

"It matters to me," I said. "And it matters to the kid we saved. And it matters to the universe we're going to save."

I reached into my pouch. I pulled out the picture of Vanessa.

"We messed up, Logan. We both did. We failed the people we loved. We let them down."

I held the picture over the fire.

"But we can't change the past. We can only change the ending."

I dropped the picture.

It curled. It blackened. It turned to ash.

"So let's not fail the next ones," I said. "Let's save the world. Not because we're heroes. But because we're the only ones left."

Logan watched the picture burn.

He took a deep breath. He wiped his face.

"Okay," he said.

"Okay?"

"Okay. Let's save your damn world."

He stood up. He offered me a hand.

I took it.

His grip was strong. Anchor strong.

"Maximum Effort?" he asked.

I smiled beneath my mask.

"Maximum Effort."